king’s plea asking that he teach him the faith that he had learnt, Nigrodha offers a sermon on earnestness: ‘Earnestness is the way to immortality’, he tells Ashoka, ‘indifference is the way to death; the earnest do not die, the indifferent are like the dead.’ Ashoka is said to have made an offering of four lakhs of silver and eight daily portions of rice to Nigrodha. Thereafter, according to this tradition, promoting and propagating Buddhism became the hallmark of his reign. As we shall see later, it also became the connecting narrative thread which ensured that the faith reached Lanka, where the text that tells this story was composed.

As with the fierce Ashoka of the *Ashokavadana*, we have no direct evidence that the emperor’s initial years of rule were dominated by a spiritual quest. Considering that it took him some years to consolidate his position and be consecrated, such a quest appears unlikely. But a revealing series of inscriptions—the first that Ashoka caused to be inscribed—give us the emperor speaking in the first person about what Nigrodha preached to him. The sermon concerned the importance of ‘zeal’—which Ashoka is said to have realized a year or more after he had visited the Buddhist Sangha. His zealousness, the fruit of it, and the possibility that his example would be more generally followed are spelt out in those first epigraphs. It could therefore be that the sermon on earnestness that the *Dipavamsa* speaks of was derived from Ashoka’s own rendering of his transformation.

Perhaps such posthumous stories contain elements that are within the realm of possibility, or perhaps they do not. The verifiable truth is that Ashoka’s transformation had little to do with his quest for a spiritual preceptor; in fact, it had very little to do with spiritual matters at all. I say this with some confidence because it is through the emperor himself, in words that he himself formulated, that we learn of his metamorphosis being the consequence of activities which fell squarely within the realm of certain very material matters of state. It was a common kingly pursuit which became the starting point for Ashoka’s radically different rule and life.